WUC GRAZ 2026

Infrastructure Is Influence: Takeaways and Starter Kit

© 2026 Scott Faranello

Thank you for downloading this document and for attending my talk at WUC Graz 2026. It has two parts: the takeaways from the talk, and a starter kit to help you put research infrastructure into practice as soon as you're back at work.

What's inside

- The big idea and the five pillars
- A guide to finding your organization's research
- Starter rules for each pillar
- A prompt to apply ResearchOps rules using AI

Part 1: The big idea and the five pillars

For UX researchers, influence doesn't come from a seat at the table. It comes from research infrastructure: a home for all of an organization's research, and a set of rules that make it safe, trusted, and ready to use.

Why the usual advice falls short

The usual advice for gaining influence is to build stronger relationships, tell better stories, speak the language of business, and get a seat at the table. These are worth pursuing, but they rarely lead to lasting influence. Five problems get in the way:

Problem	What it means
Influence is a one-sided goal	Gaining influence is a researcher's goal. Decision makers have their own goals, and being influenced by a researcher isn't usually one of them.
Research is a line item	Budgets, timelines, technical limits, and business goals all inform a decision. Research is one input among many, not the driver.
Timing is everything	Researchers often join projects late, when it's hard to change course.

Problem	What it means
Research is democratized	Designers, product managers, marketers, and HR all do research. Even with a seat at the table, researchers can't be at every table.
Research is easily forgotten	When a project ends, research goes into team folders, onto laptops, or stays in someone's head, and is rarely shared.

Check your organization's research

Whether you're a researcher or someone who does research without the title, how many of these can you say with confidence?

- ☐ I can find and access all existing research across my organization.
- ☐ I know how many research projects are being done across my organization.
- ☐ I know who is doing research across my organization.
- ☐ Everyone doing research follows the same guidelines and rules.

If you couldn't check all four, you're not alone. Most organizations don't have a system for collecting, organizing, and sharing research, and what they learn is easily forgotten.

Organizational amnesia

Organizational amnesia is when an organization forgets what it has already learned, because its knowledge has no home and no system for remembering it.

The result: teams repeat research, hear the same complaints year after year, and mistake user problems for feature requests, because root causes are identified too late or not at all.

Research infrastructure

Research infrastructure is made of two things:

1. **A home** for all of an organization's research. A research repository can provide this.
2. **A set of rules** that make research safe, trusted, and ready to use. ResearchOps provides these.

Kate Towsey describes ResearchOps as "the systems that enable people to do research, consume research, and act on research." I'd add one step before all of these: **know what we know.** Before any project begins, anyone doing or using research should ask, "What do we already know?"

The five pillars

Emma Boulton's Eight Pillars of User Research map what an organization needs to support research. These five create the rules that turn organizational amnesia into organizational memory.

Pillar	What it does	Questions it answers
Governance	Protects the research	Did we get consent? Do we need to protect personal information? Who can view it, and what should they see? How long should we keep it?
Data and Knowledge Management	Organizes research so patterns show up	What was learned? When? Who learned it? Is it correct? Does similar feedback already exist?
People and Scope	Guide how research is done and used	What counts as a finding? Who reviews it? When should a researcher step in? How do findings become decisions?
Tools and Infrastructure	The home for what we know	Is research easy to find, share, and use? Are the rules being applied?

People and Scope are separate pillars in Boulton's model; here they work together. The first four pillars set the rules. Tools and Infrastructure is the home for what we know, and the presentation layer people use to interact with it.

The other three pillars (Environment, Recruitment and Admin, and Organizational Context) matter too, and can be combined in many ways to solve other problems.

About the rules

What are rules? Human decisions applied to every piece of research that enters the repository. They come in three forms:

- **Standards:** what research must include before it goes in, such as a date, team, method, and signed consent.
- **Criteria:** how research is judged once it's in. For example, when the same problem shows up again and again, a researcher reviews it before it becomes a feature request.
- **Permissions:** who sees what, and for how long. For example, HR research might be visible only to HR, and recordings deleted after a year while the findings are kept.

Where do they come from?

- Policies you already have, such as consent, data privacy, and data retention.
- Research standards, such as what counts as a finding and how strong the evidence must be.
- Problems you're already seeing, such as repeated studies, research no one can find, or one comment treated as a pattern.

Who defines them?

- Researchers draft them, because they understand the rigor it takes to conduct and collect research.
- Legal and privacy review them, especially in regulated industries like banking, healthcare, and insurance.
- The people who do and use research help shape them. Infrastructure only works when everyone who does and uses research is involved.

Don't rely on AI to write your rules. AI doesn't know your organization or what it needs to trust.

How are good rules defined?

- **Plain language,** so the repository, the AI tools in it, and the people using it can all apply and understand them.
- **Specific enough to apply, not interpret.** "Research should be high quality" is open to interpretation. "A finding needs evidence from more than one participant" is not.
- **Tested on real research** before they're rolled out, to see what breaks, what's unclear, and what's missing.
- **Improved over time.** Rules are never finished. Review them regularly.

The rules are the product. AI can quickly answer "What do we already know?", but it should never decide on its own what we trust. Whatever tool you use for your repository, make sure your rules can be applied.

What organizational memory changes

With a home for research and rules that make it safe, trusted, and ready to use, organizational amnesia becomes organizational memory. Here's what that does to each of the five problems:

Problem	What organizational memory changes
Influence is a one-sided goal	It's now shared organizational knowledge.
Research is a line item	It's the evidence decisions start from.
Timing is everything	Problems are known before a project begins.
Research is democratized	Research is already there, at every table.
Research is easily forgotten	It now has a home and rules.

This is where infrastructure becomes influence.

Where to start, by role

If you are…	Start here
A UX researcher	Map where research lives across teams, including research done by non-researchers. Then propose the first two rules to the people who use research most.
A research or ResearchOps leader	Bring researchers and research users together to agree on what counts as a finding, and when a researcher should step in. Then build those rules into your repository.
A designer, product manager, or anyone doing research without the title	Before your next project, ask “What do we already know?” When you finish, add what you learned where others can find it.
A manager or decision maker	Ask teams to explain what’s already known before approving new research, and support a shared place for research to live.

Part 2: Organizational Memory Starter Kit

You don’t need a ResearchOps role, a budget, or formal approval to start. This kit walks you through three steps you can begin the week you get back to work. Start small, adapt everything, and build the rules together with the people who use research.

Step 1: A guide to finding your organization’s research

Before you can build a home for research, you need to know where it is today: in team folders, on laptops, in someone’s head. You’re looking for where it lives, not judging what it says.

Research inventory

Add one row per place. The first two rows are examples; replace them with your own.

Where it lives	Owner (team)	What kind of research	Sensitive data?	Who can access it	Notes
Shared drive, UX folder	Design	Interviews, usability tests	Participant names in notes	Design team only	Mostly from the last 3 years
Support ticket system	Customer Support	Complaints, feature requests	Yes, customer details	Support team	Ask before using

Places to look

- Research and design folders on shared drives, SharePoint, or Google Drive
- Annual and pulse surveys, including employee surveys
- Support tickets, call recordings, and complaint logs
- Ideas portals and feedback forms
- Team chat channels where feedback gets posted
- Analytics and A/B test results
- Sales and account management notes
- Personal laptops and notebooks (ask people directly)

A “not an audit” message

Some teams may worry you’re questioning their work or planning to take it. Send something like this before you ask:

```
Hi [name],

We're mapping where research and customer feedback live across [organization], so teams can find and reuse what we've already learned.

This isn't an audit. We only want to know where research lives, who owns it, and who can access it. We won't move or share anything without your OK.

Could we have 15 minutes this week to discuss?
```

Step 2: Starter rules for each pillar

Adapt these to fit your organization. Don’t try to adopt them all at once. Start with two or three, write them in plain language, and treat them as version 1.

Governance: protects the research

1. Consent to store and reuse the research is attached before upload.
2. Names, emails, and other personal details are removed before upload.
3. HR, legal, and health research is restricted by default. Its title and owner are visible, but its findings are not.
4. Recordings are deleted after 12 months. Findings are kept and reviewed every two years.

Data and Knowledge Management: organizes it so patterns show up

1. Every study includes a title, date, team, method, and number of participants.
2. Every finding uses tags from the shared tag list.
3. Every finding is labeled High, Medium, or Low confidence, with one line explaining why.
4. New findings are checked against existing ones and linked when they match.

People and Scope: guides how research is done and used

1. One person’s comment is a quote, not a finding. A finding needs a pattern across participants.
2. When the same problem appears in three or more studies, a researcher reviews it before it becomes a feature request.
3. Research involving sensitive topics, vulnerable people, or expensive decisions is reviewed by a researcher before it’s acted on.
4. A finding goes into the backlog only with a link to its evidence.

Tools and Infrastructure: makes research findable, shareable, usable

1. Anyone in the organization can search the repository without asking for access, except for restricted research.
2. Research goes only into tools approved for that kind of data.
3. Every AI answer cites the studies it came from.

A good first pair: what counts as a finding, and when a researcher steps in

What counts as a finding? A finding is only added to the repository when it answers all five of these:

Question	What to write	Example
What was learned?	One plain sentence	Agents lose notes when a call is transferred.
What's the evidence?	Method and how many people	Interviews with 12 agents; 300 call recordings
When?	Month and year the research was done	March 2026
Who learned it?	Team or person, and who to contact	Contact Center Design team
How sure are we?	High, Medium, or Low, plus one line on why	Medium: one study, but a large sample

Agree on what each confidence level means. A starting point to adapt:

- **High:** seen in two or more studies, and the research is recent enough that nothing important has changed since.
- **Medium:** seen in one solid study, or in older research that hasn't been rechecked.
- **Low:** a small sample, a single source, or anecdotal feedback. Worth checking before acting on it.

When does a researcher need to step in? Anyone can ask, "What do we already know?" A researcher steps in when judgment is needed. Pick the situations that fit your organization:

- The same problem shows up across three or more studies. It's a pattern, not a feature request.
- Findings conflict with each other.
- The research involves sensitive topics, vulnerable people, or personal data.
- The decision is expensive or hard to reverse.
- No research exists for an important question, or for a whole group of users.
- The research is old enough that it may no longer be true.

Write them together

- Hold one 60-minute session with two or three people who use research to make decisions, such as a product manager, a designer, and someone from legal or privacy.
- Keep the rules where people already look, like your wiki, SharePoint, or the repository itself, not in a new tool nobody opens.
- Make a team, not one person, responsible for keeping the rules up to date. If only one person owns them, the rules can disappear when that person leaves.

- Set a date to review them, three months out.

Step 3: Apply the rules

If you already have a repository, see whether it allows your rules to be built in. If you don't, gather some existing research in one place, such as a shared folder or a tool your organization already allows, and start there.

Findings template

Copy this for every study. It puts "What counts as a finding?" into practice.

```
Study: [title]
Goal: [what the study set out to learn]
When: [month and year]
Who ran it: [team, and who to contact]
Method and sample: [e.g. interviews with 12 agents]
Access: [open to everyone / restricted: contact owner]

Finding 1: [what was learned, in one sentence]
Evidence: [what supports it]
How sure we are: [High / Medium / Low] because [one line]
Tags: [from the shared tag list]

Open questions: [what this study didn't answer]
Review by: [date to recheck, e.g. 2 years out]
```

Starter tag list

Most repositories let you add tags, but they don't decide which tags to use or what they mean. If one team writes "login issue" and another writes "sign-in problem," the pattern disappears. Agree on a short list:

Tag group	Example tags
Who	Customer, Employee, New user, Vendor
Goal	Find information, Complete a task, Get help
Problem type	Can't find it, Too many steps, Confusing wording, Error or bug, Missing feature
Where	Website, App, Contact center, Internal tool
Journey stage	Discover, Sign up, Use, Get support

Rules for tags:

- One tag per idea. Pick one name and list its synonyms so people can find it (“Sign-in”: also login, log in, authentication).
- Use a few specific tags per finding, not many broad ones.
- New tags go through the team that owns the rules.
- Review the list every quarter: merge duplicates and retire tags nobody uses.

Governance checklist

Run this before research goes into the repository or into an AI tool.

- [ ] Participants agreed to this research being stored and reused, not only used for the original study.
- [ ] Names, contact details, and other personal information are removed or hidden.
- [ ] Access is set: open to everyone or restricted with a named owner to contact.
- [ ] A retention date is set, so you know when to review or delete it.
- [ ] The tool you’re using is approved for this kind of data.
- [ ] Sensitive research (HR, legal, health) stays restricted, but its title and owner are listed so it isn’t repeated.

A prompt to apply ResearchOps rules using AI

Paste this into an AI tool your organization already allows. Replace the three bracketed parts with your rules, your research, and your questions.

Run the governance checklist first: make sure you’re allowed to use that research in that tool.

The AI finds what the research says. Your rules decide what you can trust. People make the decisions.

```
You are helping our organization answer one question before a project starts: "What do
we already know?"

Use ONLY the research provided below. Do not use outside knowledge, and do not guess.
If the research doesn't answer something, say "Not found in our research."

OUR RULES
[Paste your rules here: what counts as a finding, your confidence levels, your tag
list, and when a researcher must step in.]

OUR RESEARCH
[Paste or attach your research here. Each study should include its title, date, who ran
it, method and sample, and findings.]

MY QUESTIONS
[Paste your questions here, numbered.]

For each question, answer in this format:

1. Answer: what our research says, in two or three plain sentences.
2. Sources: the studies it comes from, with date and who ran them. Every statement must
trace to a study.
3. How sure we are: High, Medium, or Low, using our confidence rules, with one line on
why.
4. Where research disagrees: any conflicting findings, or "None found."
5. What we don't know: gaps, including people or groups no study has included.
6. Next step: one of these, with a reason:
- Use what we know
- Do a quick check (the research is old or thin)
- Do new research (nothing exists)
- Talk to a researcher first (if our rules say a researcher must step in)

Then list:
- Patterns: the same problem showing up across several studies or teams.
- Restricted research: if any study is marked restricted, say only that it exists, its
topic, and who to contact. Never share its findings.

Other rules:
- Never include names or personal details about participants.
- Never present a single study as settled fact.
- Recommendations are advice. People make the decisions.
```

Tip: start with a few well-documented studies. The answers are only as good as the research and the rules you give it.

Keep going

All you need is a home for research, a set of rules that make it safe, trusted, and ready to use, and a desire to turn organizational amnesia into organizational memory.

Let’s make research unforgettable.

> **Want to see what this looks like in practice?**
> I’m happy to walk you through a demo I created using Claude.
>
> **Email:** faranellos@gmail.com
> **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/sfaranello

Sources

- Emma Boulton, *The Eight Pillars of User Research*, ResearchOps Community
- ResearchOps Community, *Revisiting the 8 Pillars of User Research as a foundation for ResearchOps*
- Kate Towsey, *Research That Scales: The Research Operations Handbook*, Rosenfeld Media